University of Alicante

Computer Engineering – Specialisation in Computing

VAR: Computer Vision and Robotics

3D Gaussian Splatting

Mathematical Foundations and Rendering Pipeline

A Comparative Study with Neural Radiance Fields

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1 Introduction

1.1 Novel View Synthesis

Novel view synthesis (NVS) aims to generate photorealistic images from arbitrary viewpoints given a set of images captured from known camera positions. Applications include virtual reality, autonomous driving, and digital heritage preservation. Deep learning has replaced traditional multi-view stereo methods with learned representations, and two have emerged as state-of-the-art: **NeRF** [2] and **3DGS** [1].

1.2 Neural Radiance Fields (NeRF)

NeRF represents a scene as a continuous volumetric function:

$$F_\theta : (\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{d}) \longrightarrow (\mathbf{c}, \sigma) \tag{1}$$

where F_θ is an MLP mapping position $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^3$ and viewing direction $\mathbf{d}$ to colour $\mathbf{c}$ and density σ. A pixel colour is computed by integrating along the ray:

$$\hat{C}(\mathbf{r}) = \int_{t_n}^{t_f} T(t)\, \sigma(\mathbf{r}(t))\, \mathbf{c}(\mathbf{r}(t), \mathbf{d})\, \mathrm{d}t, \quad T(t) = \exp\left(- \int_{t_n}^{t} \sigma(\mathbf{r}(s))\, \mathrm{d}s \right) \tag{2}$$

Limitations. NeRF requires 1–2 days of training and renders at 5–30 s/frame due to the cost of per-pixel MLP evaluations.

1.3 3D Gaussian Splatting (3DGS)

3DGS represents the scene as a set of *explicit, learnable 3D Gaussian primitives.* Each Gaussian $\mathcal{G}_i$ stores a position $\boldsymbol{\mu}_i \in \mathbb{R}^3$, a covariance $\boldsymbol{\Sigma}_i$, an opacity o_i, and view-dependent colour as spherical harmonic (SH) coefficients. Rendering is performed by projecting each 3D Gaussian onto the image plane (splatting) and compositing the resulting 2D splats via differentiable alpha blending on the GPU, achieving >90 fps at 1080p. Gaussians are initialised from a SfM sparse point cloud and optimised end-to-end with adaptive density control (Section 6).

1.4 Comparative Analysis: NeRF vs. 3DGS

Table 1: Qualitative comparison between NeRF and 3DGS.

Criterion	**NeRF**	**3D Gaussian Splatting**
Representation	Implicit (MLP)	Explicit (Gaussian primitives)
Rendering method	Ray casting + volume integration	GPU rasterisation (splatting)
Render speed	<1–30 fps	>90 fps (consumer GPU)
Training time	1–2 days; 5 min (Instant-NGP)	20–40 minutes
Memory (inference)	Low (MLP weights)	High (∼1 GB/scene)
Editability	Difficult	Easy (explicit geometry)

NeRF's implicit representation handles smooth geometry naturally; 3DGS trades spatial continuity for hardware-accelerated rendering and explicit editability.

The remainder of this document covers the mathematical foundations of 3DGS: geometric representation (Sections 2–**??**), the rendering pipeline (Sections **??**–5), and the optimisation strategy (Section 6).

2 Mathematical Representation of 3D Gaussians

2.1 The 3D Gaussian Kernel

A 3D Gaussian is defined by its unnormalised influence kernel:

$$\boxed{\mathcal{G}(\mathbf{x}\,;\,\boldsymbol{\mu},\boldsymbol{\Sigma}) = \exp\left(-\frac{1}{2}(\mathbf{x}-\boldsymbol{\mu})^\top\boldsymbol{\Sigma}^{-1}(\mathbf{x}-\boldsymbol{\mu})\right)} \tag{3}$$

where $\boldsymbol{\mu} \in \mathbb{R}^3$ is the centre and $\boldsymbol{\Sigma} \in \mathbb{R}^{3\times 3}$ is a symmetric positive semi-definite (SPSD) covariance matrix. The kernel equals 1 at $\mathbf{x} = \boldsymbol{\mu}$ and decays with the Mahalanobis distance; the locus $\mathcal{G} = e^{-1/2}$ traces the *one-sigma ellipsoid*.

2.2 Gaussian Primitive

Gaussian Primitive

Each primitive $\mathcal{G}_i$ is an oriented, anisotropic ellipsoid characterised by:

- $\boldsymbol{\mu}_i \in \mathbb{R}^3$ – **position**,
- $\boldsymbol{\Sigma}_i \in \mathbb{R}^{3\times 3}$ – **shape and orientation** (eigenvalues = squared semi-axis lengths; eigenvectors = principal axes),
- $o_i \in [0,1]$ – **opacity**,
- $\mathbf{f}_i \in \mathbb{R}^{(L+1)^2\times 3}$ – **colour** as SH coefficients (Section 4).

2.3 Scene Representation and Parameter Count

A scene is a finite mixture of N primitives:

$$\mathcal{S} = \left\{(\boldsymbol{\mu}_i,\, \boldsymbol{\Sigma}_i,\, o_i,\, \mathbf{f}_i)\right\}_{i=1}^{N} \tag{4}$$

Typical scenes contain $N \in [10^5, 10^7]$ Gaussians stored as flat GPU tensors. For SH degree $L = 3$ each Gaussian has 59 learnable parameters $(3+4+3+1+48)$, so 3×10^6 Gaussians require ≈ 700 MB in `float32`.

3 Covariance Factorisation and Rotation

3.1 The RS Factorisation

To guarantee SPSD throughout optimisation, 3DGS parametrises $\mathbf{\Sigma}$ as:

$$\boxed{\mathbf{\Sigma} = \mathbf{R}\,\mathbf{S}\,\mathbf{S}^\top\mathbf{R}^\top} \tag{5}$$

where $\mathbf{R} \in SO(3)$ is a rotation matrix and $\mathbf{S} = \mathrm{diag}(s_1, s_2, s_3)$ with $s_k > 0$. SPSD is guaranteed since $\mathbf{v}^\top\mathbf{\Sigma}\,\mathbf{v} = \|\mathbf{S}^\top\mathbf{R}^\top\mathbf{v}\|^2 \geq 0$ for all $\mathbf{v}$. Expanded:

$$\mathbf{\Sigma} = \mathbf{R}\begin{pmatrix} s_1^2 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & s_2^2 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & s_3^2 \end{pmatrix}\mathbf{R}^\top \tag{6}$$

The columns of $\mathbf{R}$ are the eigenvectors of $\mathbf{\Sigma}$ and s_k^2 are the eigenvalues, so s_k are the principal semi-axis lengths.

3.2 Quaternion Representation of Rotation

$\mathbf{R}$ is stored as a unit quaternion $\mathbf{q} = (q_w, q_x, q_y, q_z)$, $\|\mathbf{q}\| = 1$, which uses only 4 parameters and avoids gimbal lock:

$$\mathbf{R}(\mathbf{q}) = \begin{pmatrix} 1 - 2(q_y^2 + q_z^2) & 2(q_x q_y - q_w q_z) & 2(q_x q_z + q_w q_y) \\ 2(q_x q_y + q_w q_z) & 1 - 2(q_x^2 + q_z^2) & 2(q_y q_z - q_w q_x) \\ 2(q_x q_z - q_w q_y) & 2(q_y q_z + q_w q_x) & 1 - 2(q_x^2 + q_y^2) \end{pmatrix} \tag{7}$$

After each gradient step $\mathbf{q}$ is renormalised: $\mathbf{q} \leftarrow \mathbf{q}/\|\mathbf{q}\|$.

4 Colour Modelling via Spherical Harmonics

4.1 Motivation

Surfaces exhibit view-dependent appearance (specular highlights, metallic reflections). In 3DGS each Gaussian encodes its view-dependent colour compactly using **spherical harmonics (SH)**, an orthonormal basis on the unit sphere S^2

4.2 View-Dependent Colour

For Gaussian $\mathcal{G}_i$ and channel $k \in \{R, G, B\}$, the colour in direction $\mathbf{d}$ is:

$$\boxed{c_{i,k}(\mathbf{d}) = \sum_{l=0}^{L} \sum_{m=-l}^{l} f_{i,k,l}^{m} \, Y_l^m(\mathbf{d})} \tag{8}$$

where $f_{i,k,l}^{m}$ are learned coefficients. In matrix form: $\mathbf{c}_i(\mathbf{d}) = \mathbf{F}_i \, \mathbf{y}(\mathbf{d})$, with $\mathbf{y}(\mathbf{d}) \in \mathbb{R}^{(L+1)^2}$ the vector of SH values. SH evaluation is purely polynomial, making it very efficient on the GPU.

4.3 Degree Selection

Table 2: SH parameter count by degree.

Max Degree L	**Coeffs/channel**	**Total (RGB)**	**Effect**
0	1	3	Constant diffuse
1	4	12	Linear shading
2	9	27	Quadratic specular
3	16	48	Sharp specular (used in 3DGS)

The original 3DGS paper uses $L = 3$. Training starts at $L = 0$ and unlocks one degree every 1000 iterations, stabilising early optimisation by fitting low-frequency geometry first.

5 Alpha Blending and Accumulation Rendering

5.1 Alpha Compositing

Given N colour contributions $\{c_i\}$ with opacities $\{\alpha_i\}$ sorted front-to-back, the final pixel colour is:

$$\boxed{C = \sum_{i=1}^{N} c_i \, \alpha_i \, T_i}, \qquad T_i = \prod_{j=1}^{i-1}(1-\alpha_j), \quad T_1 = 1 \tag{9}$$

T_i is the transmittance reaching layer i; $\alpha_i T_i$ is its effective contribution.

5.2 Per-Gaussian Opacity at a Pixel

The opacity of Gaussian $\mathcal{G}_i$ at pixel $\mathbf{u}$ combines the learned opacity o_i and the 2D kernel response:

$$\boxed{\alpha_i(\mathbf{u}) = o_i \cdot \exp\!\big(-\tfrac{1}{2}(\mathbf{u}-\boldsymbol{\mu}_i')^\top (\boldsymbol{\Sigma}_i')^{-1}(\mathbf{u}-\boldsymbol{\mu}_i')\big)} \tag{10}$$

5.3 Incremental Accumulation

Algorithm 1 Alpha Blending per Pixel (front-to-back)

Require: Sorted Gaussians $\{i_1, \ldots, i_K\}$ covering pixel $\mathbf{u}$
Ensure: Pixel colour $C(\mathbf{u})$

```
C ← 0,   T ← 1
for k = 1, ..., K do
    α ← α_{i_k}(u)
    if α < ε_min then continue
    end if
    C ← C + c_{i_k} · α · T;   T ← T · (1 − α)
    if T < ε_stop then break
    end if
end for
return C + T · C_bg
```

$\epsilon_{\text{min}} = \epsilon_{\text{stop}} = 10^{-4}$. Depth and opacity maps are obtained by the same accumulation replacing $\mathbf{c}_i$ with z_i or 1:

$$D(\mathbf{u}) = \sum_i z_i \, \alpha_i \, T_i, \qquad A(\mathbf{u}) = 1 - T_{\text{final}} \tag{11}$$

5.4 Connection to NeRF Volume Rendering

The 3DGS formula is the discrete equivalent of the NeRF volume integral. Identifying $\alpha_i = 1 - e^{-\sigma_i \delta_i}$ and $T_i = \prod_{j<i} e^{-\sigma_j \delta_j}$ recovers Eq. (9) exactly. The two methods differ only in *how* α_i is produced, not in the compositing formula.

6 Optimisation Mechanisms: Densification, Pruning, and Opacity

6.1 Training Objective

All parameters are optimised end-to-end by minimising:

$$\boxed{\mathcal{L} = (1-\lambda)\,\mathcal{L}_1 + \lambda\,\mathcal{L}_{\text{D-SSIM}}}, \quad \lambda = 0.2 \tag{12}$$

$\mathcal{L}_1$ ensures per-pixel accuracy; $\mathcal{L}_{\text{D-SSIM}}$ preserves structural detail by penalising blurry renderings.

6.2 Optimiser

Adam with per-group learning rates (position: 1.6×10^{-4} decaying to 1.6×10^{-6}; scale: 5×10^{-3}; rotation: 10^{-3}; opacity: 5×10^{-2}; SH degree 0: 2.5×10^{-3}; SH 1–3: 2.5×10^{-4}).

6.3 Adaptive Density Control

Every 100 iterations (from iter. 500 to 15 000), the mean position gradient

$$\bar{\nabla}_i = \tfrac{1}{K} \sum_{k=1}^{K} \|\nabla_{\boldsymbol{\mu}_i'} \mathcal{L}\| \tag{13}$$

drives two operations when $\bar{\nabla}_i > \tau_{\text{grad}} = 2 \times 10^{-4}$:

- **Clone** (small Gaussian, $\max s_k < \tau_{\text{size}}$): create an exact copy; both are optimised independently. The region needs more primitives.
- **Split** (large Gaussian, $\max s_k \geq \tau_{\text{size}}$): replace with two Gaussians at scale $s_k/1.6$, positions sampled from $\mathcal{N}(\boldsymbol{\mu}_i, \boldsymbol{\Sigma}_i)$. The primitive covers too large an area.

6.4 Pruning

At the same frequency, Gaussians are removed if: (1) opacity $o_i < \epsilon_\alpha = 0.005$, (2) world-space size exceeds τ_w, or (3) projected 2D radius exceeds τ_v (removes "floaters").

6.5 Periodic Opacity Reset

Every 3000 iterations all opacities are reset to $\alpha_{\min} \approx 0.01$. Gaussians that contribute to the scene recover high opacity quickly; redundant ones do not and are pruned at the next pruning step. This prevents ghost Gaussians from accumulating throughout training.

References

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[3] Matthias Zwicker, Hanspeter Pfister, Jeroen van Baar, and Markus Gross. EWA splatting. *IEEE Transactions on Visualization and Computer Graphics*, 8(3):223–238, 2002.